munity incensed and once again reaffirmed Rakesh's narrative that an arrogant central government was out to kill the farmers. The major farm unions announced new agitations, including mahapanchayats in several districts, and *rail roko abhiyans*. Meanwhile, in Punjab, where the whole state was in flux over the farmers' issue, the agitation was taking a communal tone with Sikh radicalism raising its head again. The Centre could no longer look away, more so with assembly elections to Punjab and UP just months away. The end was near.

Talking to INDIA TODAY after the victory, Rakesh said, "We were very clear from day one that we won't go back. '*Kanoon wapasi, ghar wapasi*' was our slogan. Our fight is not over yet. If the government does not fulfil its promise on MSP and other matters, then we will again protest." The agitation took a heavy toll on the farmers too. The Samyukta Kisan Morcha, the body spearheading the protest, says close to 700 farmers died from varying causes, while participating in the protests.

THE STRUGGLE IS REAL

Rakesh is no stranger to protests, having led several of them in the past two decades. The son of legendary farmer leader Mahendra Singh Tikait, who brought New Delhi to its knees when over 200,000 of his cohorts overran the capital in 1988 demanding higher prices for sugarcane and lower electricity tariffs, the BKU frontman has been to jail 42 times.

The Tikaits belong to the powerful Jat community who constitute around 6-7 per cent of the total population of the state but are a considerable 15 per cent in western UP. The community holds sway in almost 100 seats across 20 districts of western UP, including Baghpat, Muzaffarnagar, Meerut, Shamli, Agra, Aligarh and Hathras. After Mahendra Singh's death in 2011, elder brother Naresh took over the mantle of BKU president while Rakesh became the spokesperson and led the protests on the street. He led the Kisan Kranti Yatra, a protest march from Haridwar to Delhi in 2018 demanding unconditional loan waivers, clearing of dues by the sugar mills, and higher prices for the crops. Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) chief and the late Ajit Singh's son Jayant Chaudhary calls Rakesh a man with a can-do attitude. "It takes a lot of courage and intensity to keep the fight going. He did it. Tikait's contribution is immense in this *andolan*," he says.

Born in 1969 in Sisauli town of Muzaffarnagar, Rakesh completed his MA from Meerut University before joining Delhi Police as a constable in 1988. He quit in 1995 to work full-time with the BKU. Dharmendra Malik, a senior member of the BKU, says, "Since the day he joined BKU, he hasn't spent more than 10 days in his village. I have been working with him since 2000. He has been active on every issue related to farmers." Rakesh is married and has three children. His family stays in Sisauli. A close aide says he is himself "a powerful sugarcane farmer and has several farming lands in Muzaffarnagar". Other than their traditional holdings, the Tikaits had got around 70 bighas of land (42 acres) as gifts from the community when the late Mahendra Tikait became head of the Baliyan Khap when he was just eight years old back in the 1940s.

The Tikaits, though, have made several missteps in their political excursions, perhaps why Rakesh made it clear he will not be contesting the coming UP assembly election unlike some of his colleagues in Punjab. He had contested the 2007 election from the Khatauli seat with Congress support but lost his deposit. The story continued in 2014. An RLD functionary who didn't want to be named says, "In 2013, after the Muzaffarnagar riots, Tikait mobilised the Jat community and the khaps in western UP to throw in their lot with the BJP. The polarisation broke the unity between the Jats and Muslims in the region." The Tikaits and then RLD chief, the late Ajit Singh, later mended fences and Rakesh even fought the 2014 Lok Sabha poll on an RLD ticket from Amroha but again lost badly. Later, the Tikait brothers accepted that helping the BJP was their biggest mistake. This time around, Rakesh was particular about keeping the secular nature of the agitation intact.

A TASTE FOR CHILLIES

Tikait doesn't like sweets and raw green chillies are mandatory for lunch. A close aide says, "Tikait's lifestyle is very simple. During the *andolan*, he only ate dal and roti but he needed green chillies with his food"

In the past three elections (in 2014, 2017 and 2019), the Jats had voted overwhelmingly for the BJP. The farmers' protest has offered a ray of hope to the RLD, the traditional Jat party, to regain its dominance in the region. Party chief Jayant Choudhary has held rallies with farmer leaders, including the Tikait brothers, in the past few months, looking to unite different sections against the BJP. Though Tikait has announced that he won't support any political party in the assembly poll, the agitation has changed the dynamics of western UP politics and made the BJP's path tough here.

The success of the farmers' protests comes at a time when India is at a peculiar crossroads, when hypernationalism rules the air and any sign of dissent is crushed. The Covid crisis had dissipated the other big protests, most notably against the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), but Tikait and the farmers' win helped reaffirm a gilded touchstone—that in a democracy the people's will is supreme and even governments with brute majorities have to submit to it at times. ■